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The Names

by Florence Knapp

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Discussion Questions

1. According to the author's glossary of names, "Cora" means "the core of the story," and yet Cora is less present in some storylines. Do you think Cora is the heart of the novel --- or her son? Whose story feels most central? Or is it some of each? And how do you see the characters relating to the literal meanings of their names?
2. At one point, Gordon Jr. observes that though he "can't even explain it to himself...he has always wanted to be called Luke." Have you ever wished your name were different? Are there certain names that you feel called to or that you innately dislike?
3. Did you find yourself rooting for one of the boys' storylines over another? Why?
4. Which boy has the better life? And which narrative offers the best life for the other characters? Which storyline feels likeliest?
5. Maia's relationship with her brother is significantly different in each storyline. How do the parental dynamics at play affect the relationship between the siblings?
6. Consider the role of loneliness in the novel. How does isolation complicate Cora's life? Her children's? Conversely, where do instances of friendship and kindness alleviate the family's suffering?
7. The unnamed vet who helps Cora in Gordon Jr.'s story reappears as Felix in Bear's. Did you spot any other shared elements or characters in the narratives? What did all three stories have in common?
8. In Gordon Jr.'s storyline, Maia suppresses the uncomfortable truth of her mother's abuse. How does the theme of truth play out in each iteration of the story?
9. In Bear's narrative, Cora ends up in a happy relationship with Felix and finds a true friend in Mehri. In Julian's story, he learns not to fear conflict with Orla, and Sílbhe finds Cian; in all stories, Maia makes her way -- eventually --- to real love. How do these alternative demonstrations of love intersect with the abuse at the core of the novel?
10. Depictions of masculinity are many and varied throughout the novel. How do the story's male characters fall prey to toxic masculinity or become trapped by it? Which characters represent masculinity in a positive way?
11. Bear, Julian and Gordon Jr. all contend with the fear that they've inherited their father's predisposition toward violence. What do you think we inherit from our families? From our names?

Author Interview

Behind the Scenes: A Q&A with Florence Knapp

Q: With such an original novel concept and structure, how did you come up with *The Names*?

I think it grew quite organically out of my own interests. I've always been fascinated by the things that shape us as people and a name, which we're given at birth and then carry out into the world with us, seems like it has the potential to have a profound impact on that. Either because of the associations we bring to it ourselves, or through those drawn by others.

Q: Can you walk us through your creative process in crafting *The Names*? And how did you find the characters evolved during the writing process?

Early on in the writing process I had a sense of who this boy might be in each version of his life, as his mother's choice of name has such an instant effect on his upbringing and the role his domineering father will play. The trickier thing was deciding who each would become by the end of the novel, if they were to transition to nuanced, flawed, relatable, fully rounded adults, where the reader could truly understand and believe in their motivations. I spent a long time thinking these things over and, as I felt my way towards an answer of sorts, I filled in the plot points that might act as the stepping stones to help each of my characters reach that place.

Q: In your book, names hold deep symbolic significance leading our main character to three quite contrasting lives, as well as impacting the lives of those around him. How do you see the role of names in the broader cultural or societal context?

Although I find the traditional meanings of names interesting, I'm more fascinated by the subconscious associations we bring to them, and how these might influence us. When we learn someone's name, we naturally make certain assumptions, often before ever meeting them face-to-face. We hear their name – Brenda, Dolly, Tarquin, Mohammed, Sunday, Boris, Fern, Riz – and form an idea of how approachable, professional, or friendly they're likely to be. It might cause us to make unwitting assumptions around age, class, culture, race, gender. Or perhaps our opinion might be coloured by a name that reminds us of an old classmate, a favourite grandparent, someone in the public eye. These things have the potential to affect how a job application might be received, or whether we'll cross paths with a potential partner. Although in many ways, this seems an odd thing – because a name is most often something of our parents' choosing, rather than our own. But it's impossible to unpick where our name ends and we begin, when we're all the product of our upbringing.

Q: Did you intentionally choose these names for your character to represent certain traits or themes? What led you to choose Bear, Gordon and Julian?

Yes, these names were there pretty much from the start. In one version of this boy's life, I wanted him to have a name handed down through the generations. I settled on Gordon, which feels suitably traditional, and then quickly imagined the pull this young boy might feel towards a bottle of gin bearing his own name. In another narrative, I wanted a name that felt larger than life, to explore how it might feel if this boy were, contrastingly, given the opportunity to spread out and really become his name. And then there is Julian. At least at first, this name treads the middle ground between these two. It means sky father, ostensibly a tribute, but is actually given in the hope he might transcend his troubled earth father.

Q: With the three separate timelines following Bear, Gordon and Julian, did you face any particular challenges in terms of pacing or narrative structure when writing *The Names*? How did you work through them?

By accident, rather than design, the structure of this novel offered me a relatively safe place to work from as a writer. We revisit in turn each version of this boy's life every seven years, and once I'd established that, it provided a very clear roadmap to follow.

Q: Are there any other books, music, or movies that you feel influenced you or helped during your writing process for *The Names*?

Yes, I love this question. I think everything we read, watch or listen to probably alters our perspective a little. But if forced to pick out a few, I'd say: the plot and pace of Kiley Reid's *Such a Fun Age*; the psychological insight of Stephen Grosz's *The Examined Life*; the warmth, nostalgia, and character development of the television series, *This is Us*; a particularly horrifying painting by Goya; those lyrics from the Bruce Springsteen track *Dancing in the Dark*, where he sings: 'I check my look in the mirror, wanna change my clothes, my hair, my face'. I think Julian feels this sentiment deeply during one particular scene in my novel. Although it also seems to speak more generally, to what it is to wonder who we might be if we could break free of the confines of our own self. And yes, perhaps even our own names.

Q: If there's one key message or takeaway you hope readers get from *The Names*, what would it be?

Hope. My novel explores what it is to be shaped by our circumstances – our name, our upbringing, the people around us. By fate and chance, too. But what I hope readers will also feel is that, as Bear, Julian, and Gordon move into adulthood, each gains a sense of his own autonomy and, within the context of the hand he's been dealt, does ultimately get to decide the person who he wants to be in the world. To me, this feels a profoundly hopeful thing.

https://goldsborobooks.com/blogs/subscriber-exclusive-content/behind-the-scenes-the-names-with-florence-knapp?srsltid=AfmBOor6zGj6kdVTX_mRfbL5jghopvU2qyKZu6-gumRBhFJfJVzCZ5OC

Author Biography

Florence Knapp has previously written a nonfiction book about a centuries-old method of quilt making, as well as contributing to a book for the Victoria and Albert Museum, *Patchwork & Quilting*. She lives just outside London with her husband and their dog, Nell. Their two children have now flown the nest. *The Names* is Knapp's debut novel and will be translated into more than twenty languages.

Reviews

THE NAMES

by Florence Knapp • RELEASE DATE: May 6, 2025

This noteworthy debut explores a sobering topic with creativity, cleverness, and care
An imaginative exploration of the long-term unfolding of an abusive marriage.

Knapp's debut is a kind of thought experiment focusing on the family of a British couple named Cora and Gordon, beginning with the birth of their second child, a boy who is nine years younger than his sister, Maia. In the prologue, it is 1987, and Cora and little Maia are off to the registrar to officially name the baby. Gordon—a respected doctor in the community, though a terrifying, violent tyrant at home—wants him named Gordon. But on the way to town, little Maia suggests he be named Bear, which "sounds all soft and cuddly and kind." The opening chapter shows Cora making three different decisions: In the first section, in a rare act of defiance, she follows Maia's suggestion. Next, she selects the name she herself most wants: Julian. Then she follows directions: The baby is Gordon. Each of the subsequent chapters—which are all divided into three sections—jumps ahead by seven years, tracking the consequences and implications of Cora's naming decision until the boy is a 35-year-old man. If the intention and construction of the book are a bit didactic, expressly designed to illustrate and explore the dynamics of domestic abuse, the boldness and thoughtfulness of Knapp's plotting add complexity and a welcome unpredictability. As supporting characters are added to each storyline, some appearing in just one, others in two or three, and as the main characters develop in different ways in each scenario, the novel's structure pays off as Knapp intended it to, inviting the reader to think about not just the ripple effects of a single decision and the workings of an abusive family but also about a profound and classic concern of fiction: How things we can predict and/or control in life interact with things we could never have seen coming.

This noteworthy debut explores a sobering topic with creativity, cleverness, and care.